

Part 3 Write-up

Question 1:

Self-repair is a common conversational strategy people use to manage how they are perceived, often to improve their image and appear more likeable. By examining the examples from the Balloon Task (a text-based dialogue) and the face-to-face conversation in the TOWIE video, clear differences emerge in how this behavior is expressed. These differences highlight how context, whether interaction is text-based or in person, shapes the way speakers monitor, adjust, and present themselves during conversation.

In the Balloon Task, instances of self-repair are usually marked with an asterisk and presented in a separate, subsequent message. For example:

“What do you think?/ *about his wife”

“For sure higher than a Mozart baby/ Mozart kid*”.

In this instance, the asterisk clearly signals that the speaker is correcting what was previously written. In text-based conversations, the original error remains visible, and the correction follows in a separate turn. This differs from face-to-face interaction, where speakers often repair their speech immediately, using cut-offs that indicate self-interruption and restart, as in:

LCK: “I’m no- try- justify things?”

LCK: “[bu-] (0.4) we’ve been un unhappy for a long time”

What is also particularly interesting is that speakers sometimes use expressions typical of face-to-face conversation, such as “no” or “Listen” to rephrase their sentences, even though the interaction takes place in a text-based setting.

“Listen, yeah no, I feel that...”

In addition, it becomes clear that texters often attempt to mimic features of live dialogue by including expressions such as “I don’t remember the names hahah” or “ah it’s ahe/ ops,” and by using emojis like a thumbs-up or a laughing face. Through these strategies, they attempt to make the interaction feel more personal and immediate,

compensating for the lack of face-to-face cues. In this way, they soften their tone, make their intentions clearer, and help prevent possible misunderstandings.

Finally, we can observe that clarification requests in text-based dialogue often need to be explicitly verbalized, as in:

“What does that even mean?”

“You need to explain what you mean with that!”

“You mean that they all jump? Or what”

In text-based interactions, participants lack access to each other’s gaze, tone, or intonation, which makes it difficult to initiate repair in more subtle, implicit ways. In contrast, the TOWIE video shows that face-to-face dialogue includes embodied cues and facial expressions, which can serve as subtle signals for initiating repair. Some illustrative examples are:

YAZ: °mm hm°=

YAZ: ↑no we ca:n't ((shakes head once))

YAZ: [no >no no< you]((vertical hands motion downward)).

Question 2:

Having a face-to-face interaction in the TOWIE video makes it easier for the HAut effect to occur. HAut refers to the hearer’s autonomy (negative face), meaning their desire to act freely and not be imposed upon or restricted by others. In face-to-face interaction, HAut can be realized not only through words and language, but also through non-verbal cues such as gestures, facial expressions, physical positioning, and prosody. These additional communicative resources can intensify how threats to autonomy are conveyed and interpreted.

If we look first at the language being used, one noticeable feature in the TOWIE conversation is the frequent use of imperatives. Commands naturally limit the other person’s choices and reduce their freedom to respond on their own terms. In this way, they directly challenge the hearer’s autonomy (HAut). This kind of language tends to appear more often in reality TV when emotions run high and tension starts to build. It becomes especially clear in moments such as the following:

LCK: no, listen=

LCK: no >no no< listen

YAZ: [no >no no< ((punctuates with hand)) you listen you listen].

Suggestions, of course, can have a similar to imperatives effect, since the speaker indicates that the hearer is expected to act in a specific way:

YAZ: =no(w) lets be honest [you message] me as well

YAZ: let's leave it alone .hhh=

YAZ: =[let's] block each other's, num[bers].

In addition, the constant interruptions and breakdown of turn-taking also signal a restriction of free will. Throughout the dialogue, the two speakers repeatedly interrupt each other and largely ignore each other's need to be heard:

YAZ: no and vice-versa

LCK: no, listen=

YAZ: =no(w) lets be honest [you message] me as well

LCK: [listen]

LCK: no >no no< listen

YAZ: [no >no no< you]((vertical hands motion downward))

LCK: [() if you] [(don't me will leave) °lets leave it alone°]

YAZ: [no >no no< ((punctuates with hand)) you

listen you listen].

Questions and requests also play a central role in the conversation when they pressure the hearer to adopt a particular moral stance. So questions like: “la- ho:w do you think that's made me feel as a pe:rsn [la-]” and “ ho:w d'you think that's [made my confidence] feel?” are not neutral; they implicitly expect a specific, sympathetic response from the hearer rather than leaving space for an open answer.

Finally, since this is a face-to-face conversation, non-verbal cues also carry a lot of meaning. In the TOWIE video, things like facial expressions, gestures, and eye contact add extra layers to what's being said. For example:

LCK: *was wrong*. ((direct eye contact with Yaz))

YAZ: ((raised eyebrows)) I just think the way that you (0.4)

YAZ: [I'm asking you la-] ((raised eyebrows, eyes wide open, raised hand)).

Here, the eye contact, raised eyebrows, wide eyes, and hand movements all add emphasis and put subtle pressure on the other person, showing how meaning is communicated not just through words but through body language too.

Question 3:

There is no question that significant differences exist between a face-to-face conversation between two people and a text-based interaction with an AI chatbot. Although chatbots employ some conversational techniques similar to those humans use, such as maintaining politeness, they still lack fundamental conversational skills and emotional competence. Thus, a discussion with a chatbot often lacks key interactional features and tends to appear as plain, disconnected turn-taking.

For example, reading the following conversation I had with ChatGPT:

Me: Choose between 1 and 2

ChatGPT: I'll go with **2**.

Me: No, I meant 1 and 10

ChatGPT: Ah, got it! Between **1** and **10**, I'll pick **10**.

Here, ChatGPT adjusts its answer each time I clarify without complaining or asking for justification. Another example illustrates this further:

Me: say hello

ChatGPT: Hello! 🙌 How's your day going so far?

Me: no I meant goodbye

ChatGPT: Ah, got it! Goodbye! 🙌 Wishing you a great day ahead.

Me: say goodbye

ChatGPT: Goodbye! 🙌 Take care and see you next time!

Me: I told you to say hello

ChatGPT: Ah, now we're back full circle! Hello! 🙌 Nice to be saying it properly this time.

These examples clearly show that ChatGPT does not react defensively. In human-to-human interactions, similar situations might trigger mild irritation or requests for clarification. ChatGPT, however, willingly rephrases its responses according to the user's instructions, no matter how many times it is asked. The conversation never escalates, and it consistently maintains politeness and a smooth flow, even when the dialogue could easily become frustrating.

What is more, ChatGPT tends to apologize and correct itself only when someone points out that it made a mistake. Here is its answer when I pointed out that what it said was wrong:

Yes—I apologize! 😊 I got mixed up earlier, and I'm sorry for the confusion.

Thanks for pointing it out. 🙏

Once again, we notice the extensive use of emojis as an attempt to appear more friendly and polite to the user. This is a crucial part of self-repair, especially when physical or facial expressions cannot be used.

Of course, having a conversation with a chatbot is still far from the experience of naturally interacting with another person, as the dialogue often lacks emotional escalation and remains a simple exchange of information. Dialogue systems could improve by training chatbots to respond emotionally and understand context—being able to negotiate, rather than merely rephrasing or apologizing when they are “wrong.” Introducing elements such as defensiveness, ego, or resistance could enhance naturalness and make interactions feel closer to face-to-face human conversation.